'India supports a peaceful political settlement which is acceptable to all sections of the people of Afghanistan.'[77] The parallel anti-Pakistan partisan narrative of collaboration between the Afghan Mujahideen and the Kashmiri separatists, with active support from the ISI, had failed to stem the rise of the conciliators.[78]

Kashmir connection

Most detractors of dialogue with the Mujahideen in the early 1990s (and the Taliban afterwards) argued that the Mujahideen would embolden separatism, Islamist radicalism, and militancy in Kashmir. Narayanan, who was director of the intelligence bureau until December 1989, confirms, that he was 'deeply worried' about what was going on in Afghanistan and its impact on Kashmir.[79] Indeed, Hamid Gul, former DG-ISI, had testified that the Soviet departure from Afghanistan encouraged the ISI to couple-up its wars in Afghanistan and Kashmir. Years later, Gul admitted: 'we [Pakistan] wanted to mirror the success in Kashmir by sending them into Indian-administered Kashmir to manipulate the Kashmiri people's anger at India's refusal to grant them autonomy. We would train the freedom fighters. We would arm them'.[80] Connection between Afghan Islamists and Kashmir became an enduring theme in India's approach towards Afghanistan over the decades. Even if the existence of this connection is not in doubt, the success of replicating the Afghan model in Kashmir, despite Gul's assertion and Indian conviction about the same, remains questionable. In May 1990, for instance, after tremendous media pressure, the government clarified that it was closely monitoring the activities of Kashmiri separatists and trying to assess if they had been in touch with the Mujahideen to obtain weapons and training, or even to join them to fight in Afghanistan.[81] However, no corroborative evidence emerged to confirm the presence of Afghan Mujahideen in Kashmir.[82] Though there were indications that Hekmatyar's *Hizb-e-Islami* had been training some Kashmiris, most other Mujahideen groups (especially Massoud and Rabbani's *Jamiat-e-Islami*) despite their sympathy for the cause, refused to support Kashmiri militants.[83] On 27 September 1992, Rabbani articulated his stand on Kashmir very clearly. 'We condemn oppression against Muslims wherever they may be. We hope the Kashmir issue is resolved on the